

THE FIRST TANKS

At the beginning of the 20th century

the internal combustion engine and the tracked tractor made the prospect of mobile, armored firepower on the battlefield realistic for the first time. World War I provided the impetus.

The earliest successful tank development took place in Britain. Fosters was contracted to build the first land ship, nicknamed “Little Willie,” in July 1915, although a

superior design called “Mother” was selected by the Army in February 1916.

The first tank attack took place on September 15, 1916, at Flers-Courcelette. Of the 49 tanks assigned, only nine reached the German lines, but the new weapon created a sensation in Britain. Field Marshal Haig immediately ordered 1,000 more, and work began on improvements.

The first French tanks saw combat in April 1917. They were not as capable at crossing trenches as British vehicles, but they were well armed. The most common French tank, the Renault FT (see pp.24-27), was first used in May 1918. It was the first tank to have a top-mounted turret capable of turning a full 360 degrees. 3,177 were ordered during the war.

The biggest shortcoming of these tanks was their poor reliability. Mechanical breakdowns put more out of action than enemy fire ever did, and availability dropped dramatically over multiple-day attacks. Of the 580 British tanks used at Amiens on August 8, 1918, only 145 were available the next day. Nonetheless, tanks played a greater and greater role as the war continued. During the Allied Hundred Days Offensive of August-November 1918, tanks were a vital part of the combined arms warfare that led to victory.

“We heard strange **throbbing** noises, and **lumbering slowly** towards us came three huge **mechanical monsters** such as we had **never seen before.**”

BERT CHANEY, BRITISH ARMY SOLDIER, 1916



△ **French tanks on parade**

A battalion of Renault FT-17s leads the victory parade on Bastille Day in Paris, 1919, to celebrate the end of World War I.

Key events

- ▷ **1902** The Simms Motor War Car, complete with armored hull, pom-pom, and machine guns, is demonstrated.
- ▷ **1906** Charron, Girardot, et Voigt car with Guey turret and Hotchkiss machine gun is tested in France.
- ▷ **1912** Two Italian armored cars are used in Libya during the Italo-Turkish War—the first to see action.
- ▷ **August 1914** The French Minister of War orders 136 armored cars. The first enters service a month later.
- ▷ **February 1915** The British Admiralty Landships Committee is formed.
- ▷ **July 1915** “Little Willie” is ordered from Fosters. It moves for the first time on September 9th, just 5 weeks later.
- ▷ **January 1916** “Mother” is completed, just three months after it was designed.
- ▷ **February 1916** Mark I tanks are ordered by the British Ministry of Munitions; Schneider CA-1s are ordered by the French Ministry of War.
- ▷ **September 15, 1916** At the Battle of Flers-Courcelette, tanks first see action.



△ **The Battle of Cambrai**

British Mark IV tanks were the first to penetrate German lines at Cambrai, in 1917. Here, members of the Royal Navy maneuver a tank over a trench.

- ▷ **April 24, 1918** The first tank-on-tank battle takes place at Villers-Bretonneux, between a German A7V and British Mark IVs.